



the reindeer on their migrations twice a year, with not one permanent living area. The Yamal Peninsula, (Yamal means “the end of the Earth”) is home to some groups of Nenets who travel across it seasonally. This

peninsula stretches into the Arctic Ocean and in the winter temperatures can sink to -58°F (-50°C). It is a difficult place to live but these Nenets have been living there for over 1,000 years.

Ancient beliefs

The Nenets practice an animistic religion and worship their own god *Num*. A lot of Arctic people converted to Christianity as missionaries spread their word, but in Siberia, when it was part of the Soviet Union, it was impossible for missionaries to reach the Nenets people. This means that in most instances their ways of life and beliefs are as they were hundreds of years ago.

THE SACRED SLEIGH

At times of sacrifice or on special occasions, the sacred sleigh will be unpacked by a respected elder. The sleigh carries religious idols, bear skins, coins, and anything special that has been collected in a lifetime. A sacred drum is sometimes carried, which is given in difficult times to a shaman (a religious man) who uses it to appeal to the god.



White reindeer are viewed as special and prestigious and are often chosen to pull the sacred sleigh.

Sacred sleigh

MAMMOTH IVORY

Between 5,000 and 25,000 years ago, large mammoths roamed the Yamal Peninsula in great numbers. For thousands of years the Nenets have found their ancient skeletons and used the ivory tusks to make buttons, boxes, harnesses, etc.



THE HOUSE IDOL

If a respected member of a family dies, a doll, or *yaminga*, is made with reindeer skin to represent them. The person's artifacts, such as jewelry, are attached. They are kept to protect the family and ward off evil.

SUPERSTITION

The Nenets are superstitious people. For example, women can never step over a lasso, and household contents have to be laid out in such a way so as not to bring bad luck. They have a number of religious artifacts that are carried on the sacred sleigh, which is very rarely unpacked.



As Arctic people evolved they had less facial hair since it is not practical in cold climates.

